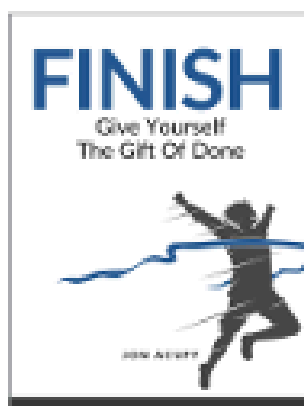




FINISH

Give Yourself The Gift Of Done

JON ACUFF

The Big “So What”



Most people find it easier to start something than to finish it. In this book, Acuff explains why it's so hard to complete what we've started, and presents a set of principles and tips to help us reach the finish line.

Introduction



In his book “Start” published in 2013, Acuff focused on helping people to get past their fears and start on their goals and projects. He later realized that people may struggle to start something, but they struggle even more to finish what they've started. For example, only 8% of people finish their New Year's resolutions—the large majority (92%) drop out along the way.



Acuff created an online video course—the 30 Days of Hustle challenge—to help people achieve their goals.

- In 2016, a researcher from the University of Memphis decided to do a study of 850 course participants. The study found that people who finished the course had on average 27% higher success rates than when they pursued goals without the course.
- Based on the results from this study and Acuff's own observations, he discovered that the key to finishing is not about working harder. It's about overcoming perfectionism, which causes us to set overly-ambitious goals, amplify our mistakes, diminish our achievements, complicate things and quit prematurely.



In this summary, we'll zoom in on how perfectionist tendencies can get in the way of your goals, and how you can overcome perfectionism to finish your plans and achieve real results.

KEY QUOTES

“Starting is fun, but the future belongs to finishers.”

“Accomplishing a goal is a lot less like taking a train across country and a lot more like driving a bumper car.”

“If you want to finish, you've got to do all that you can to get rid of your perfectionism right out of the gate. You've got to have fun, cut your goal in half, choose what things you'll bomb, and a few other actions you won't see coming at first.”

Reaching the Finish Line



Embrace Imperfection



Perfectionism is not the same as excellence—it can be an obstacle to success because it pushes you to reject mistakes and quit just because something isn't perfect.



Many self-help books focus on starting strong. It's a good idea to have a plan, but a bad idea to try to have a perfect plan.

- Imagine you aim to exercise 30 minutes a day, but miss a day of exercise after 1 week. Perfectionists are likely to quit simply because of this blemish on their impeccable record. Or, you may be doing well with your sales target, then fall short for 2 months and decide that you've fallen too far behind to catch up.
- Many people won't even *start* on a goal if they think it isn't ideal. More than 97% of respondents in an online poll said that at some point in their lives, they've decided not to jot down an idea because it didn't seem good enough. If you wait for the perfect goal, you may never get started. It's much better to start with an imperfect goal and refine it along the way.



Let go of perfectionism and embrace imperfection instead.

- In reality, mistakes are inevitable and most failures won't kill or hurt you. On the other hand, if you quit each time you encounter a setback or imperfection, you may soon become a chronic quitter. That's because each time you quit, you're breaking a promise to yourself and losing faith in your own abilities.
- Even visualization techniques focus on repeatedly imagining yourself doing something perfectly. When your actual experience turns out to be different, you may feel discouraged and stop trying.
- Beware of the might-as-well trap, i.e. thinking "Since I've already slipped up, I might as well stop altogether." The largest proportion of people drop out of The 30 Days Hustle Challenge as early as Day 2—all it takes is something small to mar their perfect plan and they decide they might as well quit.

KEY QUOTES

"We don't want B's and C's when we've got a goal. We want straight A's, especially if it's a goal we've thought about for any amount of time."

"Goals you refuse to chase don't disappear—they become ghosts that haunt you."

"Developing tolerance for imperfection is the key factor in turning chronic starters into consistent finishers."

"The harder you try to be perfect, the less likely you'll accomplish your goals."

"The day after perfect is what separates finishers from starters."

In short, perfectionism plays up our mistakes and plays down our achievements. By embracing imperfection and celebrating incremental progress, you're more likely to survive the bumps on the road to reach the finish line.

Halve Your Goals

50%

✂️ Perfectionism prompts us to over-stretch. We believe that that we must "go big or go home" and feel bad about setting small goals.

- Once you've set an overly-ambitious goal, your perfectionist tendency kicks in and tells you to quit if you can't do it properly. You tell yourself that it's better to stop now rather than waste all the time/energy and still fail later.
- The planning fallacy refers to the human tendency to consistently under-estimate the amount of time needed to complete a future task. Thinking of a big goal can be exciting at the beginning. However, the bigger the goal, the worse the planning fallacy and the more insurmountable it'd seem halfway into the process.

🔗 The solution is to cut your goals by 50%. This is not the same as doing half the work. In fact, halving your goals will actually encourage you to do *more*:

- When you reduce your goals, (i) they seem more attainable, and (ii) each time you complete a goal, you feel more motivated to keep going.
- On Day 9 of Acuff's 30-day program, participants were asked to reduce their goals by half. Those who did so improved their average performance by 63% (from their past performance), and 90% felt more motivated to work on their goal.

2X If your goal can't be halved, then double the timeframe allotted to achieving it.

❓ If you feel uncomfortable about reducing your goal, ask yourself what's the worst thing that can happen if you halve the goal or double the duration. Chances are, the real reason behind your ambitious goal is your perfectionist streak telling you to do everything now and to do it perfectly.

KEY QUOTES

"Perfectionism magnifies your mistakes and minimizes your progress."

"Goals are a marathon, not a sprint."

"Perfectionism will tell you it's now or never, forever obsessed with the idea that if you don't finish it now, you never will."

Choose What To Drop



Most of us accept at some level that it's impossible to do everything, much less to do everything well. Yet, the perfectionist in us says that we should do *more*. We feel ashamed when we don't do what we're "supposed" to do—to have an amazing career, spend loads of time with the kids, keep the house and lawn flawlessly clean and tidy, have a colorful social life, a wide range of hobbies and still have time to exercise and rest.



Instead of trying to juggle everything, then feeling like a failure when you can't, it's better to decide in advance what you'll ace in and what you'll allow yourself to suck at. Deliberately choose the goals to focus on and the goals to give up. For example, are you willing to be clueless about the latest TV programs, have fewer likes on social media, and have one of the sloppiest lawns in the neighborhood? By allowing yourself to drop the balls on things of lower priority, you free yourself from the shame of not living up to expectations in those areas.



In some areas, you may need a system or strategy in order to reduce your time/focus and still stay effective.

- For example, Acuff examined his daily emails and discovered that only a small number required a response within 24-48 hours. He sets up his emails such that he can check them only a few times a week while his assistant handles the bulk of the responses. To reduce the temptation to constantly check his emails, he moved the email app icon to a less accessible part of his phone.
- List down your daily activities and label/code them, e.g. use green for items that'd move you toward your goals and red for those that will distract you from your goals. Progressively drop 3 items from this list. You can keep changing the list as your priorities shift.



Learn to say No. It can be extremely hard to say no to your friends or when someone asks for a favor. You can't please everyone if you want to achieve your important goals. You may even need to temporarily pause certain relationships, e.g. stop hanging out for your drinking buddies every week until you've finished your project. If your friends will walk away just because of that, they're probably not worth your time to begin with.

KEY QUOTES

"More than likely, you've spent most of your life choosing to do more than is possible and beating yourself up for not being able to keep up."

"Choose what to bomb and succeed at a goal that matters."

"In order for me to go all in on things that matter, I had to choose to suck at a few that don't."

"Just say no. No long explanation. No apology. No justification. No."

 If you can't stop something totally, then simplify it. For example, whenever you have a major deadline round the corner, replace your home-cooked meals with simpler meals or food deliveries.

Motivate Yourself and Have Fun!



 Perfectionism says that if a goal is worthwhile, then it must be difficult and painful. That's simply not true. It's equally untrue that if something is fun, it's not "real" work.

 In fact, the opposite is true. You're more likely to succeed with fun goals because you'll want to take action and are more likely to perform better.

- Each time you finish a goal, you should (i) feel a sense of satisfaction and (ii) see an improvement in performance, both of which will motivate you to keep going. Participants of Acuff's 30-day program who chose a potentially-satisfying goal reported a 31% higher level of satisfaction. Those who chose something they enjoyed saw a 46% increase in performance success.
- This principle is not about choosing something fun and easy; it's about finding ways to make your goal fun. You'll still need to put in deliberate work and effort to achieve results. Ask yourself: "How could I make this goal more enjoyable?" For example, if you enjoy football but hate running, then play more football as part of your weight-loss program.
- Remember: the definition of "fun" is totally subjective. Just do what works for you, even if it appears strange or crazy to others.

 There are 2 key sources of motivation: rewards (i.e. being driven by positive outcomes you desire) and fears (i.e. being driven by negative outcomes you want to avoid).

- To significantly increase your chances of success, make it fun to achieve your goals and painful if you don't: (i) know the fears and desires that drive you, and (ii) build them into your goals and activities wherever possible.
- For example, if you're motivated by rewards and love music, then indulge in a concert or buy yourself a musical gadget

KEY QUOTES

"Perfectionism and fun are like oil and water. They don't mix. Perfectionism thinks fun is a waste of time and holds no value."

"Fun not only counts, but it's necessary if you want to beat perfectionism and get to the finish."

"Fun is supposed to be personal and often that means it's weird."

"Pick which form of motivation you need the most and then add it to as many parts of the project as possible."

when you achieve a goal. If you're motivated by fear of criticism, then force yourself to announce publicly if you miss your goal, or do something you detest as a punishment.

Remove Excuses and Self-Made Obstacles



When you try to focus on a goal, you're likely to find yourself facing these 2 hurdles:

- "Hiding places" are the safe and easy things you busy yourself with to avoid doing what you should be doing; and
- "Noble obstacles" are legit-sounding reasons for not finishing what you started.



Get out of your hiding places. To achieve your goal, you may need to perform difficult tasks. This triggers your fear of failure or imperfection, so you end up hiding behind other activities like checking your emails or organizing your files. You *appear* to be busy but are actually unproductive.

- Identify your hiding places using 3 questions:
 - (i) Are you doing this activity by chance or design? The things you do on a difficult project will always happen by design, not by accident. If you find yourself doing something by chance or habit, you're probably escaping from the real work you should be doing.
 - (ii) Can you explain clearly and succinctly how the work creates value and directly contributes to your goal? If not, you're probably just creating excuses for what you're doing.
 - (iii) Will others agree that you're working on the right things? Get external feedback by asking someone you trust if what you're doing is truly vital for your goals.

Make a list of your hiding places (e.g. watching TV, surfing the internet, checking emails). Deliberately redirect your time, energy and resources away from those activities to the ones that truly matter.

KEY QUOTES

"The more fun you add to your goal, be it in the form of fear or reward, the more likely you'll actually finish."

"Hiding places are tricky... They make you feel like you're doing well when in reality you're not getting anywhere on your most important projects."

"If you ever have to do a complicated, multistep explanation to say why what you're doing is valuable, it probably isn't."

"'What's next' will always look more interesting than 'what's now.'"

- Turn your distractions into motivators:

- (i) New ideas and opportunities will always seem more exciting than finishing an existing project. When a thrilling new idea comes to mind, don't fight it. Instead, park it aside and explore it once you finish your current project.
- (ii) Each time you feel tempted to return to a hiding place, make it conditional upon completing your existing project, e.g. you can have a movie night or a full day of TV once you complete your goal.



Get rid of the Noble Obstacles. Learn to recognize these 2 types of excuses for not finishing your goal:

- "I can't do X until Y happens". Have you ever told yourself that you can't do something until certain conditions are met? Perhaps you can't develop your business plan until you've done detailed research on 10 different businesses, or you can't start on your book until you've picked the perfect title. By making your goal unnecessarily complex, you create an excuse not to finish it. Each time you hear "until" in your sentence, pause and ask if the condition is truly necessary.
- "If I do this, then I'm a bad person." Have you ever abandoned a goal because you think it'll make you a bad person? Such "if-then" reasons could range from "If I start a business I'll have no time for my family" to "If I eat only healthy organic food then I'll end up spending a lot of money." Such reasons are flawed because you're only presenting 2 extreme options with no alternatives in between.

Perfectionists tend to complicate things unnecessarily while finishers keep things simple. Keep asking how you can make your goals easier and simpler, e.g. wear your sportswear to bed so you can work out early in the morning, or do up a priority list the night before so you can start work first thing in the morning.

Overcome your Hidden Rules



Most of us have been brought up with certain rules and limiting beliefs that're so deeply embedded in our subconscious that we aren't even aware of them.

KEY QUOTES

"Line your finish line with the dream goals you're currently using as hiding places and then watch how fast you'll run toward it."

"At the heart of it, a noble obstacle is an attempt to make your goal harder than it has to be so you don't have to finish, but can still look respectable."

"If you want it done, aim for simple."

- Become aware of your hidden rules. For example, you may be making things hard for yourself because you believe that anything worth achieving won't come easily. Or, you may feel guilty about becoming rich because you've been taught that money is the root of all evil.
- If you find yourself in a lose-lose situation, chances are you're bogged down by some limiting beliefs or hidden rules, such that you'll feel like a failure if you don't achieve your goals, yet you'll feel guilty if you do.



Overcome your limiting beliefs with 3 key steps:

- Use these 4 questions to identify the gaps:
 - (i) *"Do I really like doing this?"* If you don't enjoy what you're doing, the first step is to acknowledge it.
 - (ii) *"What's my real goal?"* If your current goal no longer excites you, step back and examine why. A true end-goal can always be achieved in many different ways. For example, you may have been doggedly pursuing the goal of making your first million dollars, when your true desire is to earn enough to have a healthy, happy lifestyle. With this realization, you can free yourself up to explore better ways of building your desired lifestyle and income stream. Keep returning to this question to ensure you're on-track.
 - (iii) *"Am I using an approach that's aligned with who I am?"* You'd get the most from your journey when you play to your strengths. If you're feeling weary and demotivated, chances are you have the wrong goal or approach.
 - (iv) *"Is it time for me to quit?"* It's a myth that winners don't quit. In reality, you won't know if something is for you until you've tried it. You won't know if you like yoga until you've tried a few sessions, and you won't know what it takes to start your own F&B business until you've developed an initial business plan. There's no shame in quitting a particular path if you realize the end-destination is not where you want to go.

KEY QUOTES

"You know you're dealing with a cuckoo when either outcome makes you unhappy."

"Make sure that what you're chasing is actually what you want to catch."

"If you pursue the right goal in the wrong way, you still end up in the wrong place."

"Finishing a goal you absolutely hate isn't a win."

- Crush the hidden rules by asking 2 questions for each rule:
 - (i) "What does this mean?" If your hidden rule says that "money is bad", then does it mean that "not having money is good"? When you think deeply about each of the hidden rules, you'd quickly realize how ridiculous most of them are.
 - (ii) "Who says so?" In most cases, you'd realize you don't even know where the rules came from nor the basis upon which they're built.
- Replace each old rule with a healthy, constructive, reality-based rule. For example, you may replace the rule "Money is bad" with the rule "Money in itself isn't good or bad; it's what I choose to do with it that matters."



Your hidden rules and beliefs define how you feel about your goals, and such emotions can overrule logic to sabotage your progress. Get rid of these inner obstacles so you can truly move ahead. Remember: there's no need to do everything by yourself. If you lack info or experience in a certain area, it's perfectly fine to seek help from others who have succeeded before you.

Use Data to Stay On-Track



We tend to remember our mistakes and failures more than our successes and small wins. Mid-way through your goals, the perfectionist in you may start telling you to quit because you're going nowhere, and blow your fears and frustrations out of proportion. Data is crucial in such instances to help you see your progress objectively.



Ideally, we want to achieve consistent or even compounded results. However, in reality, we're likely to experience cycles of ups and downs.

- Having multiple points of data helps you to see when you're in a momentary dip, shows your overall progress and ensures you're on the right path to the finish line. It helps you to make informed decisions rather than guesses. For example, you can get a more comprehensive view of your weight-loss progress if you record your clothes sizes, BMI, food intake, and the frequency, type, duration and intensity of your exercises.

KEY QUOTES

"Your goal will be a whole lot easier if you're not listening to secret rules."

"If you don't have any information of your own, someone else does and will give it to you if you ask the right way."

"Perfectionism screams failure and hides progress."

"Without data, progress virtually disappears."

"If you don't review the progress, you can't make adjustments. You can't learn from mistakes. You can't get better, and ultimately, you can't finish."

To find time for a crucial project, you can use a time-log to track your time-use and find pockets of unproductive time to free up.

- Data also allows you to review your progress based on actual facts, so you can systematically learn and refine your approach to arrive at your end-goal faster.



Even if you agree that data is useful, you may subconsciously prefer to ignore the truth than to face up to it. Most people would rather deny that they're overspending, wasting time on unproductive activities, or cheating on their diet program. Don't stay in denial until you land up in a crisis without a proper plan of action.



Measure forward and backward to learn and celebrate small wins.

- When you're in the midst of a goal, don't just look ahead as the finish line may seem very far away. Make it a point to also look backward to remember how far you've come from the starting line.
- Start by identifying 3 key measures for your goal, e.g. # hours invested in your goal, income generated, # products sold, # email subscribers, # pounds or inches lost, # steps taken, amount of debt paid off, # words or pages written, # books read.



Review past experiences. Use the lessons to refine your goal and approach so you improve your chances of future success.

- Consider questions like:
 - (i) Have you attempted a similar goal before? If so, what happened?
 - (ii) What and who was involved in the goal (e.g. people, time, money, resources)?
 - (iii) Were there specific deadlines, rewards and consequences? How did each of these elements motivate/demotivate you?
 - (iv) If you didn't finish your goals, why?
 - (v) What can you do differently this time to improve your outcomes?

KEY QUOTES

"Data kills denial, which prevents disaster. But only if you'll listen to it."

"If you don't learn what makes you work best and repeat it, you'll never get better."

- Such reviews help you to develop self-awareness, e.g. identify the conditions under which you're the most effective and productive, so you can apply these success factors in more areas of your life.

 If you're unhappy with your progress, consider 3 options:

- Adjust your goal e.g. halving it;
- Adjust your timeline, e.g. increasing or doubling your timeframe for completion; and/or
- Adjust your actions, e.g. increasing your level of activity or redirecting your energy to higher-impact activities.

Finish Strong



Theoretically, it should be easier to drive action when you're closer to the finish line. Yet, perfectionism can get in the way by triggering 3 fears of finishing:

- Fear of what comes next, e.g. once you finish writing your book, you'll have to face the readers' response and critique. Stop worrying about the next step—you can deal with it when you get there.
- Fear of an imperfect outcome, e.g. what if making your first million isn't as satisfying as you've imagined? Indeed, life tends to turn out differently from our expectations. Learn to welcome unexpected surprises rather than insist on a fixed outcome.
- Fear of uncertainty: what should you do after you've achieved your goal? If you've been working single-mindedly on your current goal, you may worry about what's next. It's ok to finish your current goal without knowing your next goal; just treat the finish line as an opportunity for a brand new start.



If you're dragging your feet to the finish-line:

- Ask yourself, "What am I getting out of not finishing?" For example, you may be avoiding the risk of failure or trying not to raise others' expectations by finishing ahead of time. Unless your reasons for finishing are greater than your reasons for not finishing, you won't succeed.

KEY QUOTES

"Reviewing your past is one of the best ways to understand who you really are and how you'll work best on a goal."

"We believe the finish line is a magnet pulling us toward it...but usually it's the polar opposite, pushing against you."

"You can't have perfect, but what you get is even better. You get a surprise."

"Don't let the fear of what's next steal the joy of finishing what's now."

"We need friends during the entire goal, but they are most critical at the finish line."

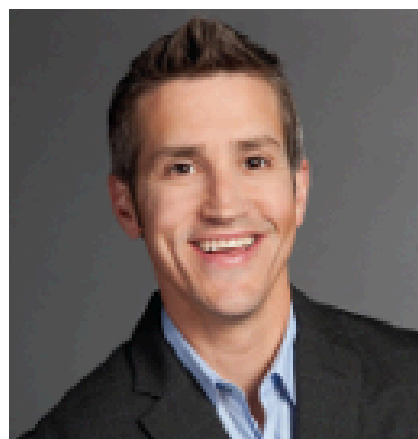
- Get support from trusted friends or family members who believe in you and can encourage you in this final push.

Other Details in the Book to Look out For



This is a lively, easy-to-read book full of humorous examples and anecdotes. At the end of each chapter, Acuff also summarizes the action steps you can take for each of the success principles above. For more details, please visit <https://acuff.me/>

About the Author



Jon Acuff is an American author and speaker. He has published several books, written for several major media companies (including Reader's Digest, Fast Company, The Harvard Business Review and Time Magazine), and also runs the blog StuffChristiansLike.net. Acuff is one of INC's Top 100 Leadership Speakers.

KEY QUOTES